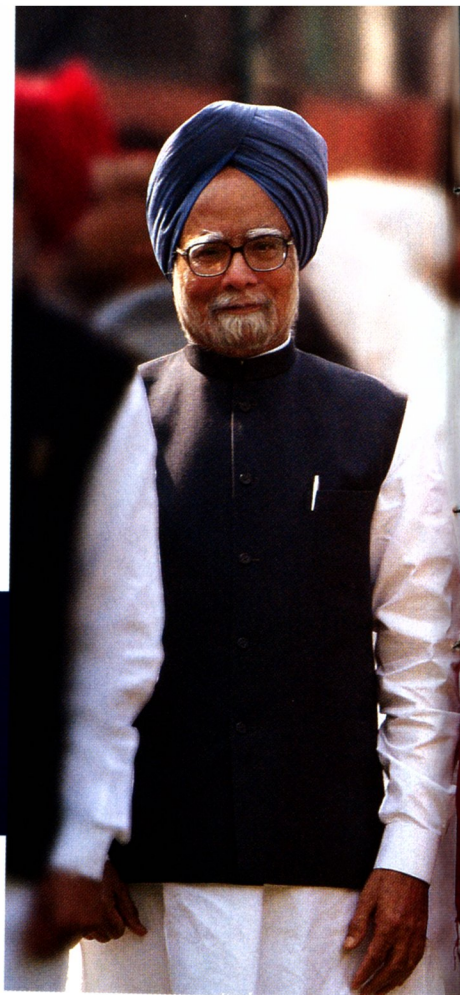


Securing the FUTURE

BY TYING UP WITH THE SAMAJWADI PARTY, SONIA GANDHI IS LOOKING BEYOND THE NUKE DEAL TO SAFEGUARD HER POLITICAL FUTURE WHICH DEPENDS ON HOW IMPORTANT A ROLE SHE WILL GET TO PLAY AFTER THE NEXT ELECTIONS



■ By Prabhu Chawla

ON AN ISSUE that's hugely important for the UPA, Sonia turned in a performance of great maturity. She played along with the Left and then dumped them.

While presenting his first Union budget in 1991, Manmohan Singh, then finance minister, said, "No power on earth can stop an idea whose time has come." Last week, the prime minister, perhaps among the least combative to have occupied the high office, decided that it was time he lived up to Victor Hugo's words and did something that would once and for all put an end to the frequent taunts of being "the weakest prime minister India has ever had". While in Japan to attend the G-8 Summit, he announced that India would be going to the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) to seek its approval for the civil nuclear agreement with the US. In doing so, he displayed a resolve that he has seldom shown in the past. After all, it was only during the last session of Parliament that, faced with the stiff opposition even from UPA allies, the Government

had almost shelved the deal. The opposition parties took it as further proof of the lameness of the governing duck. Now, there is a spring in UPA's step as reflected in the alliance's readiness to seek a confidence vote on an issue which is likely to get submerged in a year of double-digit inflation and internal security disasters.

Less than a month ago, the deal was considered as good as dead and the Gole Market commissars were gloating "we told you so". Why then this sudden confrontationist mood in UPA whose reputation for succumbing to pressure from allies even makes the word "coalition" look unholy? The reality is that UPA's decision to flex its muscles did not come overnight. For the last few months, it has been clear as morning light that the Congress was looking for an excuse to get rid of the heavy baggage that is the Left, a party which it has to confront in two big states in a few months. For the UPA Government, the Left's utility value